

TIOBE Index

March 2026

How 20+ Search Engines Rank the World's
Programming Languages

Python leads at 21.25% but posts the largest YoY decline among the top 5,
while C surges to second and Go drops from 7th to 16th.

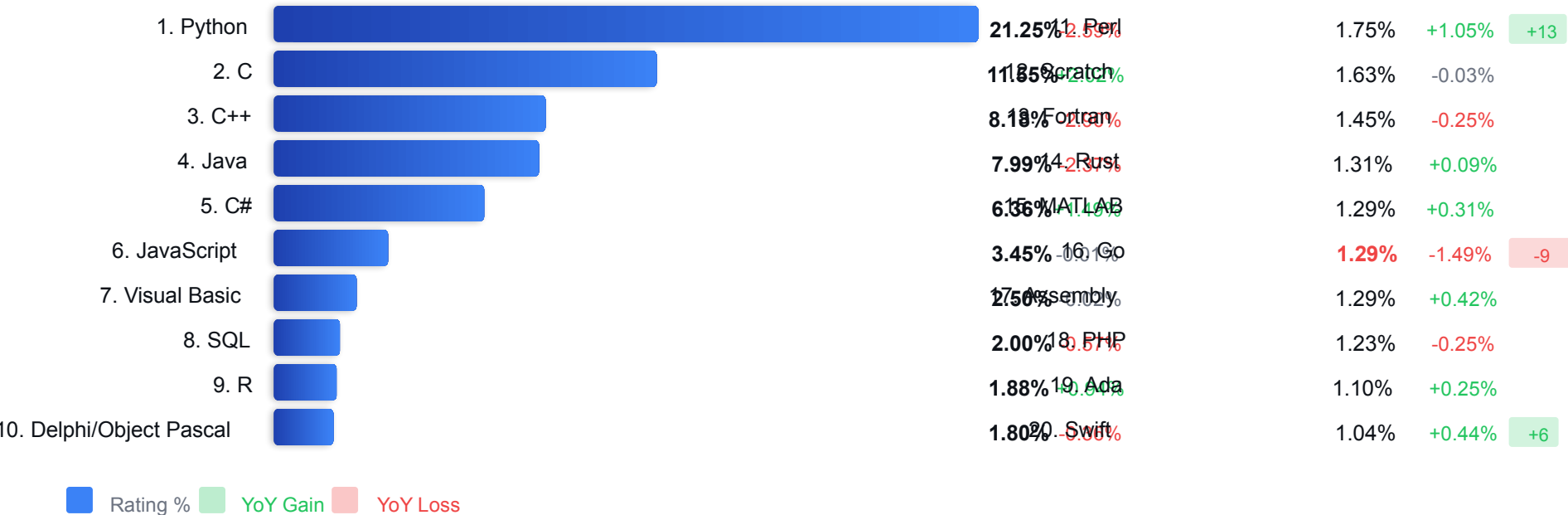
TIOBE Programming Community Index | tiobe.com

Source: Paul Jansen, CEO, TIOBE Software | Captured April 10, 2026

CONFIDENTIAL

Top 4 languages hold 49% of the index | Python dominates but C is surging

Python Holds #1 at 21.25% but C Surges to #2 with the Largest Gain



Source: TIOBE Index, March 2026 | www.tiobe.com

Perl Jumps 13 Spots, R Climbs 7, and Go Drops 9 -- The Biggest Rank Shifts of 2026

GAINERS

Languages that climbed in rankings

Perl Rank: 24th to 11th	+13 spots
R Rank: 16th to 9th	+7 spots
Swift Rank: 26th to 20th	+6 spots
Ada Rank: 18th to 19th	+4 spots
Assembly Rank: 17th to 17th	+0 spots

LOSERS

Languages that fell in rankings

Go Rank: 7th to 16th	-9 spots
C++ Rank: 2nd to 3rd	-1 spot
Java Rank: 3rd to 4th	-1 spot
PHP Rank: 13th to 18th	-5 spots
Kotlin Rank: 20th to 22nd	-2 spots

Source: TIOBE Index, March 2026 | Year-over-year rank changes

C is the only language to hold top 2 across all nine measurement points since 1986

From Lisp at #2 in 1986 to Python at #1 in 2026: How Language Rankings Shifted Over Time

Long-Term Ranking History (Selected Years)

	2026	2021	2016	2011	2006	2001	1996	1991	1986
Python	1	3	5	7	8	26	17	-	-
C	2	1	2	2	2	1	1	1	1
C++	3	4	3	3	3	2	2	2	9
Java	4	2	1	1	1	3	31	-	-

Key Historical Patterns

Python's Meteoric Rise

From unranked (1986) to #1 (2026)
25 years to reach the top position

C's Unmatched Resilience

Only language in top 2 since 1986
9/9 measurement points

Java's Long Decline

Peaked at 25%+ (2005-2018)
Now below 8%

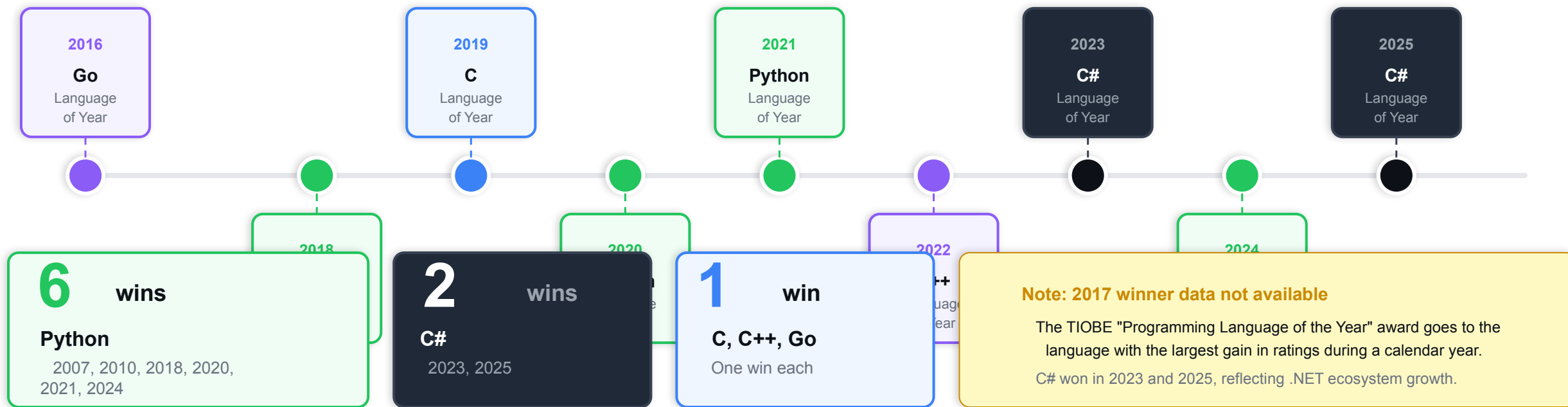
Lisp's Fall from Grace

#2 in 1986 → #26 in 2026
Early AI language now marginalized

Source: TIOBE Index historical data | 1986-2026

Python has won 6 times -- more than any other language

Python Wins Language of the Year 6 Times -- More Than Any Other Language



Source: TIOBE Index "Programming Language of the Year" award

The Top 4 Languages Hold 49% of the Index: What This Means for Your Tech Stack



Strategic Implications for Technology Decisions

- 1

Python Dominance vs. Decline Trajectory

Python leads at 21.25% but posts the largest YoY decline (-2.59%) among top 5.
Action: Monitor trajectory; don't assume continued dominance without investment.
- 2

C's Resurgence in Systems Programming

C gained +2.02% and climbed from 4th to 2nd, driven by IoT and embedded growth.
Action: Consider C for performance-critical and IoT-related projects.
- 3

Legacy Language Resilience

Perl, Fortran, and R show surprising staying power in entrenched communities.
Action: Don't dismiss legacy languages; they serve specific niches effectively.
- 4

Go's Sharp Decline & Concentration Risk

Go dropped 9 ranks despite 2016 "Language of the Year" win; top 4 = 49% concentration
Action: Diversify tech stack beyond top languages to mitigate concentration risk.

Source: TIOBE Index, March 2026 | Data-backed analysis for technology decision-makers